

How can fishes breathe under water?

Living things have to breathe, because they need oxygen to survive. People use their lungs to take in oxygen from the air, but fishes have organs called gills at the sides of their heads that allow them to get oxygen from the water.

More than 32,500 different kinds of fish live in the world's rivers, lakes, and oceans.

1 Water flows in

When a fish opens its mouth, water rushes in and flows toward its gills.



2 Water filter

The water is pushed through bony spines inside the fish's head called gill rakers. These clean the water and stop sand or mud from getting through.

2

3 Feathery filaments

The water then flows out of the fish's mouth through its gills, which contain feathery strands called filaments. These filaments take the oxygen from the water and pass it into the fish's blood.

3

Water out

Water out

